

NORTHSTAR OUTFITTERS

# Order, Fulfillment & Inventory Exception Runbook

Internal diagnosis for wrong-item, oversell, stalled fulfillment, split shipments, inventory mismatch, and carrier exceptions

INTERNAL ONLY

|                |                                                                                                     |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Version        | 3.2                                                                                                 |
| Document owner | Fulfillment Operations                                                                              |
| Last updated   | 14 September 2026                                                                                   |
| Purpose        | Internal runbook for commerce exceptions that require reconciliation beyond customer-facing policy. |

*Demo environment only. Northstar Outfitters, its customers, products, prices, orders, and commercial terms are fictional and created for SupportOps demonstrations.*

## Document Control

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Audience</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Support specialists, fulfillment operations, commerce engineering                                                                   |
| <b>Scope</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Order/fulfillment reconciliation, inventory exceptions, wrong item, partial shipment, carrier cases, post-fix verification          |
| <b>Authority</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Internal operational authority. Shopify/order data should be captured before intervention; customer-facing policy remains separate. |
| <b>Review cycle</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Quarterly or after a material policy/commerce change                                                                                |
| <b>Change control</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Material changes require owner review and publication before becoming authoritative knowledge.                                      |
| <b>Knowledge governance</b><br>Only documents marked PUBLISHED in SupportOps are authoritative for customer-facing answers. Current Shopify catalog, variant, price, availability, cart, and authenticated order state should be obtained from the approved Shopify MCP capability rather than inferred from static documentation. |                                                                                                                                     |

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# 1. Systems and Data Ownership

| Domain                    | Primary source in demo                             | Examples                                                 |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Catalog/variants          | Shopify                                            | Product, variant, option, price, availability            |
| Order                     | Shopify customer/order capability where configured | Order lines, totals, status                              |
| Fulfillment               | Shopify/fulfillment data                           | Fulfillment records, tracking, shipment state            |
| Policy                    | Published SupportOps knowledge                     | Shipping, returns, payments, fit/care                    |
| Internal exception action | Human operations workflow                          | Inventory reconciliation, carrier case, manual exception |

## 2. Order Object Checklist

- Order identifier and customer mapping.
- Order creation timestamp and financial state.
- Each line item product/variant identifier and quantity.
- Shipping address/market.
- Discounts and final-sale markers relevant to policy.
- Cancellation/refund state.

## 3. Fulfillment Object Checklist

- Fulfillment identifier and affected order lines.
- Quantity fulfilled for each line.
- Tracking number/carrier where available.
- Fulfillment timestamp and latest carrier event.
- Whether multiple fulfillments exist.
- Cancellation/replacement fulfillment if created.

## 4. Inventory and Variant Mapping

Most wrong-item or oversell investigations begin by verifying that the product/variant the customer ordered is the same variant allocated and fulfilled. Titles alone are not sufficient because similarly named variants can differ by size/color.

| Check                   | Example                               |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Ordered variant         | RidgeTrail Pro / Black / EU 42        |
| Fulfilled variant       | RidgeTrail Pro / Black / EU 41        |
| Mismatch type           | Wrong size / wrong variant            |
| Customer impact         | Cannot use product; exchange required |
| Internal classification | WRONG_ITEM                            |

## 5. Wrong-Item Workflow

1. Verify ordered line and variant ID.
2. Capture delivered item evidence where practical.
3. Determine whether mismatch originated at allocation, pick/pack, or catalog mapping if data exists.
4. Check desired correct variant availability in Shopify.
5. If available, reserve/create approved replacement path; if not, offer approved refund/alternative.
6. Create return label/merchant-funded return when required.
7. Record root cause and verify replacement order/fulfillment.

**Customer promise boundary**

Do not promise the replacement variant before current availability is verified and the operational workflow confirms it can be allocated.

## 6. Oversell / Inventory Mismatch

An oversell pattern occurs when the storefront accepts an item that fulfillment cannot allocate. Inventory mismatch can also appear when the storefront shows availability inconsistent with actual fulfillment stock.

| Observed pattern                                              | Likely issue                               | Action                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Order accepted; item remains unfulfilled; no stock available  | Oversell/allocation failure                | Investigate stock source; offer approved resolution |
| Storefront says available but repeated orders fail allocation | Inventory sync mismatch                    | Escalate inventory reconciliation                   |
| One variant impacted, others normal                           | Variant-level mapping/count issue          | Check exact variant                                 |
| Many products impacted                                        | Broader inventory synchronization incident | Raise priority; consider P1 if widespread           |

## 7. Stalled Fulfillment

| State                                                     | Interpretation           | Internal next step                              |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Order confirmed <2 business days                          | Within normal processing | Monitor unless urgent/exception signal          |
| Processing >2 business days                               | Beyond target            | Check inventory allocation and warehouse queue  |
| Fulfilled/label created, no carrier scan >2 business days | Potential handoff issue  | Verify physical handoff; carrier/warehouse case |
| Tracking in transit but no movement >3 business days      | Carrier stall            | Open carrier investigation                      |

## 8. Split Shipment Exception

Normal split shipment becomes an exception when remaining lines have no valid fulfillment path or exceed processing thresholds. Confirm the customer was not charged/fulfilled inconsistently and that each line has a clear next state.

## 9. Carrier No-Movement

8. Confirm label-created and first/last scan timestamps.
9. Confirm parcel actually left warehouse if internal evidence exists.
10. Open carrier investigation when threshold is met.
11. Set customer expectation without inventing carrier outcome.
12. If carrier declares loss, apply approved replacement/refund resolution.

## 10. Delivered but Not Received

- Review proof-of-delivery and delivery coordinates/photo if available through approved systems.
- Confirm customer completed local checks.
- Avoid blaming customer or carrier prematurely.
- Apply carrier claim/investigation rules.
- Use risk controls internally without exposing fraud labels to customer.

## 11. Address-Change Exception

Address changes after fulfillment begins can create loss/fraud risk. Verify the requester according to support controls. If the carrier has the parcel, use only supported intercept/reroute paths and avoid promising success.

## 12. Cancellation Race

A cancellation request can race with warehouse fulfillment. If cancellation cannot stop shipment, communicate that the order is already progressing and use the return process after delivery. Avoid creating duplicate refunds/replacements while fulfillment state is uncertain.

## 13. Refund / Replacement Decision Support

| Situation                               | Preferred resolution principle                                         |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Wrong item; correct variant available   | Replacement + merchant-funded return where appropriate                 |
| Wrong item; correct variant unavailable | Refund or approved alternative                                         |
| Lost shipment confirmed                 | Replacement or refund per customer preference/stock                    |
| Change-of-mind return                   | Follow standard customer policy; no internal exception unless approved |
| Damaged product                         | Replace/refund; collect evidence proportionate to issue                |
| Suspected duplicate charge              | Payments specialist verifies captures before refunding                 |

## 14. Hero Scenarios

| Scenario                                                       | Flow                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Customer ordered RidgeTrail Pro Black EU 42 but received EU 41 | Shopify order/variant -> Returns policy -> verify desired EU 42 availability -> WRONG_ITEM -> replacement/handoff         |
| Customer needs shoe under \$120 in Black EU 42                 | Shopify catalog search -> Product guide + Sizing guide -> present live matches; no internal escalation                    |
| Tracking says label created for 3 days                         | Shopify fulfillment/tracking -> Shipping guide -> handoff as carrier/warehouse exception                                  |
| Return requested day 40 referencing old 14-day document        | Current return policy -> historical/legacy conflict check -> manual exception if requested; never use legacy as authority |

## 15. Verification After Fix

13. Confirm new/replacement order or fulfillment exists when applicable.
14. Confirm correct variant and quantity.
15. Confirm financial/refund state is coherent and no duplicate resolution occurred.
16. Confirm tracking becomes available for replacement when shipped.
17. Send customer-safe update.
18. Document root cause and whether knowledge/catalog content needs correction.

## Appendix A - Reconciliation Worksheet

| Layer          | Key fields to compare                         | Mismatch signal                                   |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Catalog        | product_id, variant_id, options, availability | Ordered/fulfilled variant identity differs        |
| Order          | line variant, quantity, financial status      | Order line not consistent with fulfillment/refund |
| Fulfillment    | line quantity, status, tracking               | Missing/excess/wrong line allocation              |
| Inventory      | variant availability/allocation               | Storefront sells but fulfillment cannot allocate  |
| Payment/refund | captured/refunded amount, status              | Financial state does not match resolution         |

## Appendix B - Wrong-Item Worked Example

| Field                     | Expected                                    |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Order                     | NS-10482                                    |
| Ordered                   | RidgeTrail Pro / Black / EU 42 / qty 1      |
| Delivered evidence        | RidgeTrail Pro / Black / EU 41              |
| Desired replacement       | EU 42 Black                                 |
| Shopify live availability | Must be checked at investigation time       |
| Policy                    | Merchant-error; Northstar covers correction |
| Classification            | WRONG_ITEM                                  |

19. Confirm exact variant IDs rather than relying only on labels.
20. Check whether EU 42 Black is available now.
21. If available, create/route replacement and return label according to operation controls.
22. If unavailable, offer approved refund/alternative.
23. Check whether the pick/pack or mapping issue affects other orders.

## Appendix C - Inventory Mismatch Decision Table

| Storefront          | Warehouse/fulfillment | Interpretation                            |
|---------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Available           | Allocatable           | Normal                                    |
| Available           | Not allocatable       | Potential oversell/inventory sync issue   |
| Unavailable         | Allocatable           | Potential stale storefront inventory      |
| Unavailable         | Not allocatable       | Normal sold-out state                     |
| Rapidly oscillating | Inconsistent          | Possible sync/race condition; investigate |

## Appendix D - Carrier Case Packet

- Order and fulfillment IDs.
- Tracking number and carrier.
- Ship-from date / carrier acceptance time.
- Last scan event, location, and timestamp.
- Expected delivery window.
- Customer confirmation of non-receipt where applicable.
- Proof-of-delivery details if delivered status.
- Requested merchant resolution if carrier declares loss.

## Appendix E - Replacement/Refund Idempotency

Operational teams must avoid solving one customer issue twice. Before issuing a replacement or refund, verify whether another agent, automation, or prior workflow has already created a replacement order, return, refund, or store credit. Duplicate remediation can create financial loss and customer confusion.

| Before action | Verify                                                         |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Replacement   | No active replacement already exists; correct variant/quantity |
| Refund        | No previous full refund; amount matches intended resolution    |
| Return label  | No duplicate label/workflow unless intentionally replaced      |
| Carrier claim | No existing open claim for same parcel unless follow-up        |

## Appendix F - Postmortem Signals

- Repeated wrong-size shipments for same SKU/variant mapping.
- Multiple orders accepted for unavailable variant.
- Specific fulfillment site showing abnormal processing delay.
- Carrier lane showing repeated lost/stalled parcels.
- Catalog option labels causing customer/warehouse ambiguity.
- Return/refund workflow creating duplicate actions.

## Appendix G - Operational Metrics

| Metric                            | What it can reveal                             |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Wrong-item rate by variant        | Pick/pack or SKU mapping issues                |
| Unfulfilled >2 business days      | Inventory allocation or warehouse backlog      |
| Carrier no-movement cases by lane | Carrier/network reliability issue              |
| Replacement duplication rate      | Idempotency/process-control issue              |
| Inventory mismatch incidents      | Catalog-to-fulfillment synchronization quality |
| Refund after replacement rate     | Resolution sequencing problems                 |

## Appendix H - Incident Pattern Example

If five customers within a short period report receiving EU 41 while ordering EU 42 for the same product/color, do not treat all five as unrelated one-off mistakes. Compare variant IDs and fulfillment source. A common SKU label or warehouse mapping issue can create a systemic incident that should be contained before more orders are shipped.

24. Correlate affected order/variant IDs.
25. Pause unsafe assumptions about stock correctness.
26. Raise severity if new orders continue to be affected.
27. Correct mapping/process through the owning team.
28. Verify a fresh test/order path after correction.
29. Link individual customer resolutions to the incident for consistent communication.